

Math check: debunking “AI wastes water” with AI vs human water use per artwork (two scopes, citations)

Posted by u/PrinceLucipurr • 0 points • 58 comments

TL;DR (ratios + caveats)

Scope A (operational only)

0.53 : 1 (AI : Human) for a typical ~4h comparable artwork.

- **Swings with time + grid**
- ~**1h** sketch (often low detail, likely no colour): AI can be higher
- ~**10h** high detail: AI is typically much lower

Scope B (adds human marginal food water)

1 : 3,500 (AI : Human) for the same ~4h comparable artwork.

- **3,500 is NOT drinking water**
- It is **water used to produce the food** for extra calories burned
- Varies massively with **diet** and **time**

If you want the full breakdown, I posted the longer version and citations in the comments.

Comments

u/Mythic4356 • -1 points • 2026-01-24 18:54 UTC

i dont understand, isnt the water consumption for, humans, just what almost every human needs?

Art isnt exercise, it doesnt take much food/water

what even is this post lmao

u/PrinceLucipurr • 1 points • 2026-01-24 19:41 UTC

Not what I'm doing.

“Humans drink water anyway” is true. That’s why this is attribution, not causation.
We allocate a share of an unavoidable baseline to the activity you spent time doing.
Same logic as attributing part of your home electricity bill to your PC usage hours.

And yes, art isn’t exercise. Agreed. That’s why **Scope A** is deliberately conservative:
hydration only, no food, no upstream, no training, no infrastructure.

So why **Scope B** exists:
because people immediately scope creep from “water per output” into “training, data centres, manufacturing, testing, upstream everything”.
That’s a different question, so it gets a different scope.

I included both to stop bait and switch:

- If you want per output water: argue **Scope A** and bring numbers.

- If you want lifecycle totals: argue ****Scope B****, but then you must apply the same upstream boundary to humans too, or it's cherry picking.

If you think the human side should be lower, give your assumptions:
hours per artwork and daily hydration.

If you think the AI side should be higher, pick one figure I used, replace it with your sourced figure, and show the working.

Otherwise it's not a rebuttal, it's just a vibe.

u/Mythic4356 • 1 points • 2026-01-25 10:03 UTC

So by your logic, if a person spent his time trying to perfect an AI image, that means the same amount of water is also spent for that too

u/PrinceLucipurr • 1 points • 2026-01-25 10:41 UTC

Yes. If someone spends time refining an AI image, they're still a human existing during that time, so the same attribution rule applies.

But that doesn't rescue your objection, it actually reinforces my point, because the **time window** is usually radically smaller for AI workflows.

Like for like looks like this:

- Traditional: hours to days of manual iteration (sketch, rework, repaint, scrap, restart)
- AI: minutes to refine intent (prompting, selection, minor edits), then a short generation run

So if you include "human time spent refining", you're mostly adding a few extra minutes of human hydration to the AI side, while the traditional side still carries far larger time based attribution for comparable outputs.

Also, the "thinking/refining in your head" component is shared across both. If you want to count pure ideation time, fine, but apply it to both sides equally, and we're back to the same question: how long does each pipeline take to reach a comparable output?

Example from my own workflow: ~5 minutes total prompt refinement (2.5 + 2.5) to reach a finished hand drawn style result. If you think a traditional artist hits the same result in 5 minutes, you're not describing standard practice.

So yes, allocate the human minutes if you want. It doesn't flip the conclusion. It just makes the comparison even more obviously dominated by time spent in the traditional pipeline.

(OC 5 minute image attached in the following reply as it exceeded capacity. Generated from scratch via text only, no reference images used.)

u/PrinceLucipurr • 1 points • 2026-01-25 10:42 UTC

[https://preview.redd.it/tfya9dg5hfg1.png?](https://preview.redd.it/tfya9dg5hfg1.png?width=1536&format=png&auto=webp&s=6f28ef3aa66ab9b5be3b28d12c8e26814ea92c93)

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